anything I've seen before.' Ratan had a theory about it: 'In India and the developing world, there's a much more paternalistic equation between employer and employee. I think that creates a kinship.'

But even this did not explain it in full. Perhaps it had to do with the ethics at the core of the Tata Group. Tata companies do not exist only for profit maximization, although it is a priority. Tata Trusts, the majority owners, through their directors on the board of Tata Sons, ensure that the companies do not deviate from the fundamental belief that the wealth of the society is held by them in trusteeship.

The Trusts earn profits to give back to society. The means of earning is also equally important; they have to be ethical and serve social goals, just as the end does. The lion's share of the Tatas' wealth and that of their families has been committed to social welfare. As Thevar says, his extraordinary behaviour was influenced by the 'core values of the Tatas' and their penchant to 'give to' and 'support' people. This, therefore, makes a job at the Tatas first and foremost a public service.

Krishna Kumar felt that the way the staff behaved had nothing to do with education, training or recruitment. Instead, it has to do with the group ethos and culture and particularly, what the founder symbolizes. At the Taj, every new employee becomes a family member. This family, in turn, views every hotel guest as a member of the family too. This is the 'great secret in great organizations', commented Krishna Kumar. For the majority of the employees, what they do is not a job, but akin to family duty. And in a crisis, nobody will leave behind another family member.

Kang echoes the same sentiments, saying that all those who work with the Tata Group, including Ratan, belong to one family and when there is a crisis, all from the top to the bottom are present, doing their bit. He calls this selflessness 'Tajness'—meaning perhaps behaviour exclusive to the Taj that its employees are proud of. It entails 'genuine care of guests and colleagues', he adds. It is unique to the group because 'it has been built into their DNA' and it has come from the top and got ingrained strongly over the years. It is an integral part of the Tata culture, he feels.

Commenting on this, Bhaskar Bhat, who was the mentor of the assessment teams of the JRD QV Award for more than a dozen years, says that the Taj has a unique ethos and culture: 'There is no greater company in the group in terms of customer orientation and human qualities than the Taj. It came alive on 26/11.'